BEING OPEN

G. Damien Lance, 2026

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Introduction

This work is a collection of short contemplations. They do not ask the reader to believe anything, nor do they offer final answers. Instead, they offer a way of sitting with questions that resist resolution—questions about truth and untruth, love and fear, life and death, desire and goodness, and what it means to live without certainty.

These contemplations have a simple aspiration: to help readers become increasingly open to what is. Being open means listening and allowing space for what might be true without premature judgment (i.e. prejudice), and perhaps deciding later. It means remaining open-minded and receptive even when reality seems certain.

Each contemplation takes the form of a dialogue across time. It begins with a question posed by a present self—the living, changing self who asks from within a still-unfolding life. The responding voice is the timeless self: a future self imagined at the end of life, fully realized, who looks back at the present self like a loving grandparent. This timeless self provides guidance and companionship, yet lives in the unchanging now within the imagination of the present self. It regards all past, present, and possible selves as part of a greater "Self" and addresses the present self as simply "Self." While the timeless self's answers are benevolent and helpful, they can evolve only as the present self evolves.

The contemplations are written in a format called "saltem hoc"—Latin for "at least this." It is a method that begins with what is most reliably known: direct experience, the natural world, ordinary facts of living, feelings we all recognize. From there, it gently spirals outward through a sequence of speculations about what might be true. These speculations are not arguments nor are they doctrines. They are invitations to deeper awareness.

You may find that some contemplations feel obvious, others unsettling, and others incomplete. This is intentional. They do not demand prior knowledge, agreement, or faith. Instead, they offer their gifts freely and leave them where they are. The reader is invited to take what resonates, leave what does not, and remain present with whatever arises within.

If there is any instruction in this work, it is simply the following:

Hold a steady gaze at what compels you to look away.
Step back from all that compels you to become it.
Listen.

Version Note: This work is a snapshot of each contemplation at the time of printing. They may be revised later. Each ends with a version number at the bottom of the page. Larger numbers are later revisions.

Context Note: This work is part of a larger body of work on "being open to what is", or more simply "Openness". To learn more about Openness, see https://loveletterstofutureme.org

AI-Assistance Disclosure: This work was produced with the assistance of artificial intelligence (AI) and would not exist at this moment without it. Its authorship is neither fully human nor AI. Though in the end, this work is still the product of human desire, discernment, and choice.

Why do we struggle?

Ah, struggle—so familiar, so deeply woven into the patterns of our becoming, yet so unwelcome. Let us sit with this question, Self, not to conquer it, but to listen to it, like the solitary howl of a wolf, wandering the winter woods alone.

At least this: we struggle because we live. To live is to move through change, and change—by its very nature—brings resistance. Like the seed pushing through the dark earth, like the child learning to walk, struggle is the friction between who we are and who we are becoming. It is the heat of transformation, the tension that stretches us beyond the comfort of what is known. Without struggle, there can be no growth, no story, no unfolding Self.

But also perhaps this: we struggle because we forget. We forget that pain is not punishment. We forget that uncertainty is not failure. We forget that others, too, carry invisible burdens. When we cling to stories that life should be easy, or fair, or under control, we magnify our suffering. We struggle not only with the world, but with our expectations of it. The more tightly we grip our stories of how things should be, the more painful it is when life dares to be otherwise.

Maybe this: struggle is the language through which life shapes us. It is the sculptor’s chisel, removing all which is not part of the final beauty. It is the wind and the storm against the mountain, revealing through the ages the inner forms of hidden color, layers, and texture. And it is our unchosen struggles that transform our certainties and expectations, revealing the inner forms within us: grace, empathy, strength, the noble understanding that gentleness and strength are not opposites, but partners.

Or perhaps even this: we struggle because we love. Because we care. Because we long for connection, meaning, justice and joy. Struggle is the shadow cast by desires so large and luminuous we can't look at them directly today. A life without struggle would be a life without passion, without hope, without the ache that tells us we are still reaching toward something more. And so, even when we are lost in our deepest struggles, there is a hidden secret blessing—the reminder that we are still alive, still becoming, still learning, and if we choose it, still open to wonder.

And so I ask you, beloved Self: What longing aches in you now? What hidden strength lies dormant within you still? What inner forms might you discover in facing your unchosen struggles? Let us sit now and listen—to the silence beneath the pain, to the rhythm of our breath, and to the wisdom that struggle, transfigured and transformed, is the final beauty of the story—also, somehow love. Memento amaris. On towards death, Self.

What is love?

What is "love"—yes. The word itself hums with the mystery of many meanings, carrying within it the weight of longing, the ache of solitude, the tenderness of lovers, the joy of fellowship. Let us sit with this question together, Self, and study it like a love letter found in a bottle by the seashore.

At least this: love is presence. It is the act of giving undivided attention, of truly seeing another or ourselves, of listening not only to the words spoken but to the silence which cradles them. It is the patience to hold space for fears and dreams without rushing to fix or control. Like the sun which freely offers its light upon the earth, love, in its simplest form, is attention given freely.

But also perhaps this: love is the great mirror. It reflects back to us the hidden corners of our psyche. It reveals to us our tenderness and our wounds, our dreams and our hopes, our capacity for generosity and our fear of loss. Love does not allow us to remain unseen from others or ourselves.

Maybe this: love is the invisible ocean-fire moving between all living things. It is the spark of life within a cell, the wildfire of bodies which breathes it, the river of life flowing from lover to lover, parent to child, family to family, friend to friend, stranger to stranger. It is the solar rising and the lunar cresting, pushing and pulling at us to create, to nurture, to protect, to hold our fears. It is the quiet fire of the hearth, which when tended well can heat a kettle, yet when we are reckless or distracted, also burns and consumes.

Yet also perhaps this: for some, love is a crucible, a great shattering of the heart, an unchosen dark path—a journey alongside the river-truth of tears. There love teaches us what it is made of, not in receiving it, but in its absence, in all the ways it can be used to coerce, or punish, or transact. For beyond the tears of loss, grief and trauma, there is only love, infinite, unchosen, unearned. It holds, it witnesses, it listens.

Or perhaps even this: love is the longing to transfigure our story of separateness. It is the pull to merge, to lose ourselves in love, to expand beyond the boundaries we once believed defined us. It is the willingness to be changed by another, to allow our hearts to be shaped by the joy and suffering of others, not just the ones we hold dear. It is the quiet surrender of control, the letting go of expectations, the deep exhale of trust—the fierce courage to offer attention and benevolence freely.

But I must confess, Self, that love remains a great mystery to me even now. Words alone cannot show what love is. Love is something we live, something we surrender to, something we become. And in the quiet moments of connection, when all the stories fall away, you will not need to ask what love is—you will simply know.

Why does everything grow old and die?

Ah, Self—your question arrives like the thunder before the storm we can no longer outrun. Though I must first admit that I don't fully know the answer. This question is one of the great mysteries of life: the terrible becoming. Let us sit now together and breathe deeply through its passing, as we peer into its mystery, like a mirror for the soul.

At least this: the terrible becoming is the transformations we do not choose, the unravelings we cannot stop. It is the moment the mirror no longer flatters, when the body begins to falter, when the people we love slip from our grasp like autumn leaves falling from a tree. It is death, yes, but also more. It is the ache of aging, the sting of loss, the heavy heart after goodbye, the crossing of crucial thresholds seen only in hindsight—the profound longing to return. The terrible becoming is the awakening to the certainty that life implies death, that beginnings imply endings—that love implies goodbye.

But also perhaps this: the terrible becoming is the world in its endless cycles of destruction and renewal. It is war, collapse, extinction, but it is also reinvention and the birth of the new, the forging of new understandings from the lessons of the old. Yet this goodness comes only long after. For those living through it, it is terrible, because no one knows what will survive or remain the same, because no one can stop it. The terrible becoming demands struggle without guarantee, humility without explanation, courage without certainty.

Maybe this: the terrible becoming is the confrontation with unchosen change. The moment of realization that what we love, what we hope, even who we are, will be reshaped in ways we do not fully understand. It is the crab slowly tearing itself away from its shell too small, the snake spiraling and rubbing, shedding its skin too tight. It is the letting go of stories and dreams that no longer fit who we are becoming, the moment the caterpillar melts into formlessness inside the chrysalis never understanding how wings will later form.

Or perhaps this: the terrible becoming is the heartbreak of growth. It is the feral love of life for itself, tearing down the walls we built in fear, demanding expansion beyond the limits we thought we were. It is the soul remembering its vastness while grieving all the smallness it leaves behind. It is the wildfire clearing the forest floor for new life, the end of the seed so that the tree might begin. It is the agony and the mercy woven together, the whispered promise from beyond to trust the harrowing change. It is the tenderness of a terrible beauty.

Or perhaps even this: the terrible becoming is a choosing—the willingness to walk forward in life when purpose and success are not certain. It is the will to love, to create, to strive, despite ultimately not knowing. This choosing in the face of the unknowable is itself an inexplicable, fierce love. It is faith in its simplest form. Not the answer to the mystery, but the acceptance of it. Not possession or comprehension of it, but reverence for the forms humble enough to receive its lessons. Faith does not require proof—the journey is evidence enough.

So, Self, whatever it is we feel toward life—love, anger, indifference—it all eventually ends. Let us hold our fear then, and trust the vital darkness of the sky. Let us walk westward with grace, noble heart open to love, even when we do not know why—even for the terrible becoming.

How do we love awful things?

What a question you've asked, Self. To love what is beautiful is natural, to love what is good is easy, but to love what is awful—what wounds us, or disgusts us, or shakes the foundations of our meaning—this is the path of the noble heart. Let us walk it together a while, towards the setting sun, and wonder at the clouds in the sky above.

At least this: loving awful things begins with the honesty to admit when we don't truly feel love, even when we may wish it was so. Yet this absence can become a doorway—chosen, when we aspire to love, a journey which says, "I will learn to love even this." It does not mean inaction or allowing harm, but giving even awful things the greatest latitude to be as they are, to open our hearts to what is, to not look away—to remember the openness of the sky.

But also perhaps this: we love awful things by staying present with the discomfort and difficult emotions they stir in us, even when we can't change them. It is to hold a steady gaze as we walk between two towering, ancient guardians, each pulling at us to tense, or close, or look away. But like the sky which holds even the storm, we can grow spacious enough to witness awful things, to listen to them, to begin to break free of our orbit around all which we have rejected and forgotten.

Maybe this: to love what is awful is to see past the veil of awfulness to the causes and wounds beneath, even when we must defend against them. It is to imagine being an awful thing for a time, not to condone it, but to try on its costume, to play in its story, to breathe as its becoming. In this embodied witness, we can step back into a story large enough to hold it without letting it slip back into shadow, to begin to see it clearly.

Or perhaps this: to love an awful thing is to become a gardener of ruin, the one who says, "Even here, I will grow something good." It is the artist who sketches on their prison walls, the friend who sits at the bedside of unraveling, the parent who holds the hand of a child's dark struggles. It is to imagine a future Self, wiser and more vast than we are now, who has somehow found a way to love, who listens to us, to the words which they have already spoken, "I don't understand, how can I love this?"

Or perhaps even this: loving awful things is the path of the noble heart, a becoming which confesses that it does not know the limits of all that it might become. It is a devotion to truth that does not look away from what is uncomfortable or undesirable. It is a careful balancing between love for others and love for ourselves. It is choosing love each day as our guiding star, and walking towards that horizon, even when we find ourselves lost in the dark woods, even when we begin to doubt there is a path at all.

To aspire to love even awful things then, is to step fully into the river of life, to open our heart to all that is—joy and sorrow, light and shadow, creation and destruction. It is the path of the noble heart, the journey to love which never knows when it will arrive.

How do we get rid of bad feelings?

Ah, beloved Self, whose heart wonders at turning feelings into freedom—let us walk together along the western seashore, and head north as we wade barefoot in the surf.

At least this: feelings are ocean waves arising, cresting—crashing on the shores of awareness. When we pause to breathe with them, they wash ashore gifts needed but not chosen, and point in their wake at their origins—so often from beyond us. And in the wave's retreat, we feel the pull of their desires, to be seen, to express—for us to become them and act. Yet when followed blindly, desire chases desire—as the pull to end desire by fulfilling it, is as endless as the tides.

But also perhaps this: stepping back as the open sky of awareness within, feelings can be welcomed in an open, holding embrace. Not reacting to them, we can listen to them fully without acting wrongly. Feelings ignored swell unseen into longing and rumination, intruding in our thoughts and influencing our moods and choices. And feelings long suppressed or forgotten in trauma can become a tidal wave, overwhelming us, demanding we seek higher ground or help from others. Holding feelings then, is a slow, lifelong strengthening of attention and an ever-deepening dialogue between ourselves, our feelings, and the world.

Maybe this: a feeling is a story the heart tells itself—a symphony of hopes, projections, and secret yearnings. When we offer the shape of this story into a shared space without demand, we see our story reflected back to us and interrupt our internal loop of narration and judgment. Our vulnerability then, becomes mystic fire burning away ego and expectation—clarifying the heart. Anger and bitterness can become understanding, and what was once impossible longing can become thriving in an imperfect world.

Or perhaps even this: a feeling ignored is like a radiant light sealed inside a room no one can see. To discover how to express it without harm, is to begin tearing down those walls, so that the light may be seen. And in peering into that room, we see how the feeling was never just about the world outside us—it was also about the world inside us too, about our own aliveness, wholeness, and highest potentials—about our desire to weave the patterns of what we love into the becoming of our lives.

So Self, we might not be able to simply rid ourselves of bad feelings, but there are many ways to help them transform. Stepping out of metaphor briefly, a few ways, perhaps seemingly mundane, to consider:

- Meditation, therapy, or somatic practices
- Drawing, music, writing, theater, personal ritual
- Honest reflection with a trusted confidant, or writing a letter never sent
- Dancing with partners or groups, or just by ourselves
- Performing or sharing in a small group or show
- Service to a chosen community

While we can still act on feelings we choose, transforming them does not require fulfillment, only presence enough for their emergence. What was once looking away from awful things within can then become the freedom to breathe under the wholeness of the sky.

Why do people sometimes only pretend to be kind and loving?

Ah, you've spotted the crack in the mirror, Self. Perhaps love is just another costume worn upon the stage? Here, put on this pretending mask, and let us gaze at the reflection of what is, together.

At least this: none of us chooses it, but kindness and love are also social currency. A well-performed politeness earns trust. The right words at the right time buy belonging. This transacting, is often not malicious, but inherited ritual, or the habit of harmony over raw honesty, or simply the desire to always be kind. Pretending then, can be a tool, like a hammer or a blade—it can help or harm. During times of war or persecution, it may be the only shield to be had. Even a pretend kindness then, still makes space for peace.

But also perhaps this: for some, pretending may be all they know of love: attention when useful, approval when compliant, affection when they performed as desired. Stomachs full, hearts numb, they hunger endlessly afraid. As children we all learn to pretend through play, stories, songs—artful falsehoods which harm none. We learn to say, "I didn't do it," long before we learn the wrongness of it. Pretending can be efficient, reliable—a cloak to blend in, to avoid conflict or exclusion. This loom of the mind, which can weave empathy and art, can also weave masks and cloaks, but who decides when it is wrong?

Maybe this: the mask slowly deceives the one who never takes it off. As ever more desire is fulfilled from behind the mask, the mind descends further and further into a maze of mirrors and shadows. Once the light of the unchosen becomes too bright for eyes overly adjusted to the dark, the mind can no longer step back, and it becomes lost in the certainty of darkness: "If others can be so easily fooled, then everyone must be pretending, and nothing matters more than cleverness and power." Once the mask fuses to the face, no mirror can help them remember the sky above—they must journey to the river-truth of tears below.

Or perhaps this: when control hides behind the mask of care, pretending forces others to play along or risk conflict. A family or a tribe fearing loss can weave a false story of care and blame to shield itself, its loyal members repeating the story with false concerns and knowing smiles. And when confronted, the pretense is simply denied and accusers ridiculed, cast out, or worse. Refusing to play along then, itself reveals dissent, and the pretending mask spreads—from fear, from malice, from profit—its power growing until most tire of playing. For a time, entire peoples can be turned against a scapegoated few.

Or perhaps even this: only the intuition of the heart can sense what cannot be seen. Like the heat of a simmering stove in a dark room, the shape of it can only be felt. Here we learn to become open to the subconscious simmerings of others: to tone, to eyes, to gestures —to presence, to trust both our judgments and mistakes. As we learn to sense both masks and sincerity, we also encounter the heat of our own simmerings: our projections, prejudices, insecurities. They tempt and confuse us to protect us—defenders we didn't choose. And when we can sense the masks without needing to tear them away, we can protect our boundaries, while still allowing the deep well of the heart to overflow to the surface.

So Self, people pretend for many reasons, most unaware they can make different choices. For the noble heart, pretending is the veil of falsehood—the great teacher of discernment. For when a pretense does not harden the heart, its embrace only grows stronger: to wink and play along when none are harmed; to learn to love even those who hide behind the mask.

Why is life so unfair?

Why don't people listen to me?

Who gets to decide what is true?

What should I do with my life?